Room for Farewell
-about building spaces for bereaved

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Picture on previous page: *the Door of Farewell* from the spring exhibition at konstfack 2026 (Own photograph, 2026)

Abstract

Historically, the place where we died has been the same place where we lived. At best, a place where we felt safe and loved. But over the past hundred years, this has changed. Nowadays, most moments of death take place in a hospital or a nursing home. This means that the place where we say our final goodbyes to a loved one after death is rarely at home, but in constructed rooms in various institutions. How should these rooms be designed to make the final farewell as dignified and healing as possible?

In this thesis, I approach this question with the help of craft, phenomenology, new materialism and the will to be present.

My dergee project has centerd around the questions; Can form and materiality ground and support a person in moments of grief and loss? Can furniture and craft provide help when words are not enough? With craft and materiality, I have tried to create a room for both body and soul, a room for stillness and seriousness, a room for farewell.

Keywords: bereaved, craft, phenomenology, new materialism, interior design, wood

Table of contents

Introduction 8
Room for farewell 9
Questions and references 9
Method 11
Design process 16
To touch 16
To sit 18
To feel 20
To say goodbye 22
Reflections and self-criticism 31
Method criticism 31
A power-critical examination of rooms for farewell and possible further research 31
Which rooms are allowed to be beautiful? 31
Whose Body? - Biopolitics and Bereaved's Research 32
Conclusion 35
My material 38
Closing words 40
May 14, 2026 - the exhibition 40
Closing reflection - The most beautiful thing you can do 40
References 42

Introduction

This degree project, completed within spatial design at Konstfack in Stockholm during the first term of 2026, has its origins in two quotes. One puts into words a collective feeling and the other opens up for an answer. Swedish author Sara Stridsberg said that "My children opened a window to death that can never be closed again" (Vi läser 2010). As a parent of young children, it is very easy to relate to. The fear of death feels like a basic fear for us humans, but what happens when you have children is that the strongest fear of death is no longer centered around yourself, but the possibility that your child would die and you will have to live on after that. The second quote comes from textile artist Birgitta Nordström's master's thesis *In a Room of Rites -Cloth Meeting Human*, where she describes how one of her projects started with a request to weave blankets for stillborn fetuses in a maternity ward in Australia. "I would need such a blanket to hand over, I never know what to say, words are not enough" (Nordström 2016, p.119). Here we come in when the horror from Stridsberg's quote has happened. The window was open and death came in. Nordström tries to provide an answer to what to do when what is not allowed to happen happens, and she seeks the answer through craft. A wordless communication that finds its way into us with deep roots of archaic history and the absolute now of the senses. It is perhaps telling that it is a writer who puts words to an experience that I believe many people live with, and that it is a craftsperson who, through a wordless act, tries to find an answer, or a possible way forward.

Over one of the entrances to Stampen cemetery in central Gothenburg, there is an inscription that reads "Think about death". The cemetery is on the road between the city center and the apartment I lived in for three years and I've read that inscription through the tram window countless times. I used to like the inscription, but when I thought about it again during this project, I started to see it in a different light. Isn't it a bit patronizing. "Think about death" As if I didn't already. Holding up a sign that says death is not difficult. And not particularly productive either. Although Stridsberg does it more poetically, her quote is really not much more than saying "think about death." What's great about Nordström's work is that she approaches the question of death, if not with an answer, then at least with an attempt to face the unimaginable.

In her project, Nordström has gone into the very darkest and most difficult thing, a parent's loss of a child. Losing someone when life was just about to begin. My project faces death in a different place and time in life. My project is about *rooms for farewell*. The rooms found in hospitals that are designed for relatives to say goodbye to a person who has recently died.

In most cases, the people you say goodbye to in the Room of Farewell have been ill for some time and you have known that the end could be near. But regardless of the background, a death and the final farewell are a life-changing experience that can create various strong emotions and existential thoughts. Gaston Bachelard writes that the most important characteristic of the house is to protect daydreams and the daydreamer (Bachelard 2014, p. 48). In the same way, the most important task of the Room of Farewell is to protect those who say goodbye and their thoughts and feelings. The objects should interact with those the visitors on both a physical and an emotional and intellectual level. Be a reflection and a receiver of the body and the soul. Pallasmaa writes in *Questions of Perception* that "The timeless task of architecture is to create embodied existential metaphors that concretize and structure man's being in the world" (Holl, Pallasmaa, & Perz-Gomez 2006, p. 37).

Room for farewell

For the individual, death is everything, but for the collective, death is a number.

Every year, just over 90,000 people die in Sweden. (SCB 2026) Historically, the place where we died has been the same place where we lived. At best, a place of care and love. But over the past hundred years, that has changed. Nowadays, most moments of death take place in a hospital or a nursing home. This means that the place where we say our last goodbyes to a loved one after death is rarely at home, but in constructed rooms in various institutions. (Palliativ vård 2023)

Something interesting about the room is that it is both a public space and extremely private, but it is also a workplace. In conversations i have had, in the course of the work, with people who work in healthcare or morgues, everyone I have spoken to has said that when a death occurs, it is not something unusual or world-changing for them, but rather an opportunity to really do a good job. That is exactly where I want my objects to be useful. As a tool for hospital and morgue staff to be able to do a good job, something to use when *words are not enough*.

Questions and references

My work has revolved around the following questions: Can form and materiality ground and carry a person in moments of grief and loss? Can furniture and craft provide help when words are not enough? How can these rooms be built to make the final farewell as dignified and healing as possible?

In my work, I have approached this question through craft, materiality, sketches, and models. I have been inspired by Steven Holl and Juhani Pallasmaa's thoughts on the senses and awareness and making architecture for the human being, the whole human being. As a contrast to their anthropocentric approach, I have also tried to be inspired by new materialist ideas about materials and objects' own agency and tried to understand how this can and should influence my work.

My most important references in the project have been:

Birgitta Nordström's *In a room of rites - cloth meeting human*. An artistic research project on textiles, rites and death, where Nordström writes about creating textile art in the form of funeral pall and infant wrapping cloths (2016). The part that affected me the most is the one about when she weaves infant wrapping cloths.

Another reference that have been useful to provided a historical context for the project is Emili Karlsmo's doctoral dissertation *Rooms of farewell, the architecture and artworks of funeral chapels in the 20th-century Sweden (2005)*. The book gives a good basic knowledge in funeral chapels in Sweden with a focus on architecture and art and how it relates to the shifts in funeral costumes, modernity, secularization, and the changes towards a more multi cultural society.

I have read and been inspired by Juhani Pallasmaa and Steven Holl. Above all, Pallasmaa is connected with his criticism of the overly synfied world and the architecture he believes we live in. He instead urges us to make architecture for all the senses. But that is only the means. The goal for both he and Holl, as I understand it, is *presence*, to be in contact with the world. How architecture that addresses all our senses can ground us in our being in the world and in ourselves. That is precisely what drew me to their view of phenomenology. A dear Paul Klee quote I often think of is that "art does not reproduce what we see. It makes us see" In the same way, architecture can make us experience the world.

My third track has been to incorporate neo-materialist thinking. Phenomenology can be criticized for focusing too much on human experience and stands for an anthropocentric view of the world. In neo-materialism, one wants to broaden the subject and give agency to objects and materials as well. I still have difficulty understanding it much more than as a poetic image. Although I think it is easier for a craftsman to see the agency of the material and also the tools themselves. To create something is when the material, the tool, the hand and maybe a little brain work together. I have read Ron Richardson's "The Agency of Objects" and In my case, it has created a desire to listen more to the material and the tools, to see the forms and properties that are already in them.

In addition to my writing sources, I have also been on a study visit to the Room for Farewells at Södersjukhuset where I also had a long conversation with one of the employees the 26th of mars 2026. He had worked in a morgue and with room for farewells for fifteen years. First in Solna and then three years at Södersjukhuset. He told me that during his time it had become much more common to say a last goodbye to the deceased body at the hospital in a room for farewells. When he started working, there was one farewell a week, and now the two rooms at Södersjukhuset were pretty much fully booked every day. The rooms at Södersjukhuset are both set up in the same way with an anteroom with sofas, armchairs, and tables and a more soft atmosphere. Divided by an opaque glass wall with a large double door in the middle is the room where the dead body is. That room is more stripped down, but has a few chairs and an altar-like table.

My subject is also something that touches everyone you talk to about it. I have therefore received many stories and testimonies from friends and acquaintances about their losses, which has been very helpful in my work.

Method

In my work I have used my written sources, my visit to Södersjukhuset, conversations with people who work in healthcare and conversations with private individuals as the basis for my design. But beyond these I have let my knowledge of craftsmanship, the material itself and the making be the guide. The Anthropologist Tim Ingold describes it as that the material thinks in us, as we think through the material. "In the art of inquiry, the conduct of thought goes along with, and continually answers too, the fluxus and the flow of the materials with which we work. There materials think in us, as we think through them" (Ingold 2013, p6)

Nordström describes it nicely that "what has driven the work forward has been the design, the dialogue situation and previous experiences in my artistic work" (Nordström 2016, p.137)

David Pye describes a "workmanship of risk" (Pye 1968, p.20) and Nordströms understands it as:

> "The result and quality of the work is not predetermined but depends on the practitioner's capacity for discernment, manual dexterity, and care, something that tests throughout the entire making process until the final result. During the work, anything can happen and be re-examined"(Nordström 2016, p.138).

I often return to a quote from the pre-Socratic philosopher Meno that is included in Rebecca Solnit's essay book *A field guide to getting Lost*. The

book is about the importance of getting lost both on a physical and spiritual level and in the first chapter she tells how a student showed her the quote “And in what way do you intend to search for that which you do not know at all what it is?”(Solnit 2016, p13). As a craftsman and designer, I believe the answer is to follow the material and let the creation become a dialogue between you and it.

In my final design, I have eight objects: a double door with a handle, a bench, a table where you can place candles, a chandelier, a candle sconce, a step stool, an object for unlit candles and a table for soil. The objects have emerged during the work and relate to several different references. In what way I have tried to described in the next chapter.

Carl Martinsson

The door is the handshake of the building
Juhani Pallasmaa from *The Eyes of the Skin*

To touch

"We touch things to assure ourselves of reality" (Albers 1965, p.62) The quote comes from Anni Albers and *thought* has guided much of my work. One of the first images that came to me when I started formulating my project almost four months ago, in January 2026, was of a person grabbing the armrest of a chair when getting terrible news. Is it to prevent him self from falling, or is it to hold on to something that is solid and unchanged from the information he just received? In my ambition to ground the visitor through design, phenomenology and especially how it is expressed in Juhani Pallasmaa and Steven Holl's texts have been both inspiring and guiding. In *An architecture of the seven senses* Pallasmaa writes that:

> The skin reads the texture, weight, density and temperature of matter. The surface of an old object, polished to perfection by the tool of the craftsman and the assiduous hands of its users, seduces the stroking of our hand. It is pleasurable to press a door handle shining from the thousand hands that have entered the door before us; the clean shimmer of ageless wear has turned into an image of welcome and hospitality. The door handle is the handshake of the building(Pallasmaa 1994, p.33).

Reading that made me start thinking about what we touch in a room. While the possibility of physical interaction is of course possible, most things remain untouched. But the door handle is one of the things we do touch.

At the end of Karlsmos' book about the funeral chapel, she writes that "for many people the funeral is the first important stop in the work of mourning, but this happens later and for a long time. The funeral chapel is not a room of sorrow but a room for farewell" (Karlsmo 2005, p.350). In the same way, a room for farewell is, just as the name suggests, a room where farewell is the central thing. But how do you articulate a farewell? I chose to do it by making a door. *The door of farewell*. The title came to me long before I knew what the door would look like. And the first thing I made for the door was the handle. I wanted it to be inviting, sturdy but also intimate. A very special aspect of this type of room is that it is a

Picture on previous page: Installation view from the spring exhibition at konstfack 2026
(Photograph by Gustav Karlsson Frost, 2026)
Picture on right side: Detail of the door handel
(Own photograph, 2026)



semi-public room that you often visit for the first time, at the same time that it is a room where you are going to experience, perhaps, on of the most private things you will experience in your life—saying goodbye to a loved one. To build that trust, I believe that there must be intimacy and familiarity in the room, while there must also be a sense of self-evidence and dignity in the design. When it came to the handle, I was very keen that what the first thing the visitor gets in their hand would be all that. I knew that I wanted to make it in wood so that the hand would encounter a warm and natural material. I also wanted it to be a handle that could be gripped in several different ways. Inspired by rock climbing holds, I began to sketch different variations. In this project the circle has been recurrent as a shape and a symbol. The circle of life, the circle as a symbol of the eternal, reincarnation and how the half circle constantly speaks of the other half. In churches, the altarpiece ring usually has the shape of a half circle. This has been interpreted too mean that the circle closes on the other side of the chancel wall, where apostles, saints and the entire heavenly host in eternity celebrate communion with us. It marks our communion with all the faithful in all times (Svenska kyrkan 2023). (https://www.svenskakyrkan.se/folkungabygden/altarring-altarrund) So I ended up with the handle being a round shape that could be grabbed from several sides. To begin with, round shapes are among the most difficult to achieve in modern woodworking, except if you use a lathe, where the opposite prevails. There, the perfect circle is the basic shape. That's what got me to the lathe.

In order to turn the handle the way I wanted, I had to use a special curved turning tool that allows turning around and on the inside of an object. But by shaping the material around a corner, there was no way to see what I was doing. Instead, I had to trust my hand and how if felt to grip the handle. Which should really be a given when it's the hand that's supposed to interact with it. But by being deprived of the visual, I could really focus on how the shape felt. Several times I stood with my eyes closed and just felt what I was doing. In *The Eyes of the Skin* Pallasmaa writes about a sensory intimacy (Pallasmaa 1996, p.35) and I think that was exactly what I was looking for. Pallasmaa also writes how tactility is not only conveyed through touch but that a surface is also experienced as inviting with the eye (Pallasmaa 1996, p.43). A door handle should invite you to touch, so I also added markings in the form of circles of decreasing size as a pattern at the front of the handle so that you see that it is a patterned surface that also creates a desire to touch.

To sit

In the handle I had found a design language that I thought was both in-

Picture on right side: Making of the bench
(Own photograph, 2026)



viting to touch and intimate at the same time as it had a self-evident and dignified form. The design of the handle also offered a solution to the question of seating in the room. Right from the beginning when I started reading about farewell rooms, I realized that there are three functions that need to be fulfilled by the objects in the room. The first is a place where the dead body is placed. After researching this question, I found that the most common and practical is for the body to lie on a regular hospital bed that can be slid in and out of the room. The second was an object that could create stillness and seriousness. An object that was in relation to the body but that the visitors could direct their feelings towards that was not the body. An anchor or cornerstone in the room. In my case, I decided to make a table where you could place candles to fulfill that purpose, but more about that further down. The third concern was the need for seating. Even though the person I spoke to at the room for farewell at Södersjukhuset said that it was most common for people to stand up in the room where the deceased lies, the room requires several seats. But how do you make a room that can work for both a few visitors and a larger group, without it feeling of emptiness when there are only a few visitors and not too crowded when there are many. The room should also work for anxious and lost visitors who need clarity and security, but also encourage them to change and move around as needed. It has made me think a lot about the chair, the stool and the bench. What are the advantages and disadvantages of this three seating furniture? Based on the rooms I want to create, I think the stool and the bench have much more of the qualities I'm looking for. Especially the backless bench. A chair that is not being used constantly talks about the person who is not sitting in it. An empty chair is just that, empty. An empty bench is more of a surface. A possible place to sit, but also part of the room, of the architecture. A bench that can accommodate three does not feel empty if one person is sitting on it. But it is also possible to squeeze four people on it. On the bench you can choose distance or closeness. The stool is a place you sit on for a while. Therefore it is not surprising that the stool is empty. The stool is also made to be moved. It is naturally free in its placement, especially a round stool that you can sit on in all directions.

What the chair is is a place to sit on for a longer time. The backrest extends the sitting time considerably. But since the inner space with the body is usually not a place you are for that long, it feels like a weaker argument. It is in the outer space that you sit down for a longer time. More comfortable furniture can be suitable there. That space is not as sensitive.

The bench I have made is a development of the handle where the tactile is strongly present.

Picture on right side: Detail of bench from the spring exhibition at konstfack 2026 (Own photograph, 2026)



To feel

Now let's return to the second of the three most important objects. The spiritual anchor. It also bears features of the sensuous and tactile, but actually stems from another theme, the wondrous experience of nature. In several of the conversations I have had with people about there experience of losing a loved one, several of them testify to the small shards of nature's glory that have entered the moment and gilded it. It could be the whistle of a bird from outside, a beautiful light shining in to the room or a beautiful nature outside the window. There is a long tradition of nature and the course of nature shaping our rituals and understanding of death, so it is perhaps not so strange that people find comfort in nature and in natural experiences when a death occurs. But the question that arose in me as a designer after these conversations was whether it is possible to simulate this type of natural experience. One way has been to work with many different types of wood and use pieces with a strong woody character, but more on that later. Another has been the beaten, polished metal surface that I used for the light table. I got the inspiration for the surface from Björn Erling Evensen's sculpture *Orgelfjäril* from 1975. It is located in Enskede Företagsby, a place you would never visit unless you had a specific reason. Even though it is right next to the Woodland cemetery, the reason I happened to pass the sculpture has nothing to do with the cemetery. I was cycling with my son on the way to a doctor's appointment in Farsta Centrum and happened to cycle the wrong way. It was a sunny day and suddenly I saw something glimmer in the corner of my eye. It was like solidified rippling water that sparkles like a thousand diamonds in the sunshine. The sculpture stands in the middle of nowhere. We where late for the doctor's appointment so I didn't hade the time to stop and shortly after I realize that we hade biked the wrong way. I hade gotten lost without even knowing it and happened to find something I didn't know I was looking for. It took several weeks before I returned to the sculpture, but I knew I had found a surface that captured some of the strangeness of nature. I used the material to make a table where visitors can place a lit candel. The candles are placed on top of the table in a contaner filled with coarse sand. I wanted to use sand partly to fulfill the simple need to be able to hold one or more candles and make them stand steadily, partly for the symbolic connotations of the sand in an hourglass that counts down life or Bob Dylan's melancholic but hopeful hymn "Every grain of sand".

To say goodbye

In addition to the three central objects that make up the room, the room needs two doors. One door for the visitor. The door that connects the

Picture on right side: Installation view from the spring exhibition at konstfack 2026 (Own photograph, 2026)



room with the ordinary, living world and one door that is connected to the hospital and the morgue. The second door works also on a spiritual level and is the door through which the dead body will leave both this room and also this world. As I mentioned earlier, I was taken by how Karlsmo chose to end her over three hundred page long book by writing that the funeral chapel is not a room of mourning but a room for *farewell* (Karlsmo 2005, p.350).

There are a few different names for the type of room that I work with. The two most common are Room for Farewell and Viewing Room. Just by choosing one of them, you set a very clear tone for how the room should be used and understood. What even is a viewing room? Is the viewing of the body that is the main focus? It sounds so technical and distant. Room for Farewell instead focuses on the farewell. But it also speaks of the fact that there is room. There is space and time for the farewell. The combination of the three words also creates a feeling that it is a special room. If it had been a *farewell room*, it would have had a different sound. A sound of everydayness. No, it should be *Room for Farewell*. And *the Door of Farewell*. That name came early in the process. But how do you portray the farewell and the transition? In recent years, I have worked a lot with the wood technique *intarsia*. It is a technique where you create images and patterns by sawing together different pieces of wood veneer. The wood veneer is then glued onto a supporting board, so the veneer itself has no supporting function—the wood is used only for decorative purposes. Working with intarsia rather then regular woodworking my intention when picking wood has shifted from choosing pieces that have good properties for building structures to instead looking for pieces with interesting patterns and unusual surfaces. The door felt like a good surface to work with that technique and it also gave me the opportunity to bring more of the wonders of nature into the room. Neuroscientist Andrea Bariselli claims in the podcast *Words on wood* that the woodier the wood looks, the more positive effects it has on the user (American Hardwood Export Council 2026). During the autumn, the school began purchasing wood from a small sawmill just outside of Stockholm. They specialize in sawing up wood from trees that are felled in the Stockholm area. Because they are a small sawmill, they can take into account the specific look of the tree and pick out pieces that might not fit in a large industry but has other qualities such as exciting grain patterns and interesting color combinations. I have used a lot of their wood in my project precisely because of these qualities.

When you buy veneer, the veneer is usually taken from very homogeneous pieces of wood. Knots and other "defects" are avoided and overly clear pattern formations are avoided because in construction the veneer is often repeated and then you want to avoid revealing the repetition.

Picture on right side: *the Door of Farewell* from the spring exhibition at konstfack 2026 (Own photograph, 2026)



An exception is root- and masur veneer where the special pattern of the wood is rather rewarded. But when you make your own veneers, as I have done in this project, you can choose exactly as you like. The process began with me finding three pieces of wood that I thought had an interesting pattern. One was a piece of pine that had a clear division between the lighter surface wood and the darker heartwood that ran in a bold pattern along the length of the board. In the surface wood there were also spots of blueing that are created by a harmless fungal attack. Together, these three variations made the piece of wood look like a horizon with blue clouds on a light sky. The oak and ash that I also used had been rejected because they had cracks in them. I was able to take out pieces of the ash next to the large crack, but the oak was full of small cracks throughout the material so they had to go with the veneer.

One of the benefits of working with veneer and the type of wood collage that I had in mind for the door is that once you have your pieces you can play around with them until you find an image you are happy with. But this time it was very difficult to find the right one. My starting point was an abstract sun. The door of the sun, the door of the dead. The other door. The one that the visitor uses would be the door of the moon. The moon reflects the light of the sun. Like how the memories and person of the deceased live on in the relatives. The sun sets but its light continues to be reflected in the moon. But the sun became too much like a cross so, because the room should be welcoming to everyone, one of the most important parameters is that it should not be connected to a religion, this was not the right way to go. And above all, there was too much going on. There was an incredible amount of information already in the veneer and when they in turn were to form a strong form, it made too much of an impression. In my frustration, I came to think of Ellen Jakobsson's graduation project *Between Hands*, where she weaves surfaces from old yellowed paper she has collected (Jakbsson, 2026). The repetitive and seemingly simple rhythm of the tusk weaving creates a calm that highlights the material itself. That's why I also tried arranging my material more like a woven mat. Letting the pieces lie next to each other in a calm repetitive pattern. Immediately when I laid out the pieces in this way, a calmness arose in the composition and the patterns of the wood came to life. Suddenly, a feeling was created that there were horizons stacked on top of each other. Both that and the similarity to a carpet and a pedestrian crossing fit well with the symbolism of the door of farewell and that it is a door that leads on to something new, something uncertain. A place beyond the horizon.

Karlsmo writes about how it was common in the ceremony rooms of crematoriums built during the 20th century for the catafalque to be equipped with a lift function. So that at the end of the ceremony the coffin could be hoisted down through the floor. This was to create a natural end to the ceremony and that the coffin, which in a traditional burial is carried out of the funeral chapel to be buried, should not just remain in the room when the visitors leave (Karlsmo 2005, p.37). It is a little different in a room for farewells with the possibilities of moving the body in a dignified way at the end of the farewell, but I hope that the door still gives the visitor the knowledge that the body will departure through the door. It will not be left alone.

In the first pages of the novel *My Struggle*, Karl Ove Knausgård writes that "For the heart, life is simple: It beats as long as it can. Then it stops" (Knausgård 2010, p.9) This is followed by a technical and picturesque picture of what happens in a body when it stops living. How the blood collects at the lowest point, the body temperature drops and the joints stiffen.

> In larger hospitals, it is not enough that they are hidden away in hard-to-reach rooms; the paths there are also hidden with special elevators and special culverts, and even if you were to accidentally get lost there (Knausgård 2010, p10).

Knausgård continues by writing that it is fascinating that our culture has to hide the dead bodies when death is present in so many other places, such as in obituaries, the news and fiction. He believes that it could be because we have two kinds of death. Or that there is "a contradiction between our idea of death and death as it actually occurs"(Knausgård 2010, p.11). If that is the case, the feelings that can arise in the encounter with real, physical death are difficult to predict. I have only seen a dead person on one occasion in my life. I was nine years old and my great-grandmother, who was then 105 years old, had died in her home. Of my four siblings, it was only me and my little sister who wanted to come up and look at the body. Maybe we were too young to feel any discomfort, or maybe it was just that our curiosity was stronger. She was lying on her bed wearing nice clothes and with her hands clasped over a Bible that was lying on her chest. Her eyes and her mouth was closed. If I didn't know she was dead, it just looked like she was sleeping. I didn't touch her so I don't know what a dead body feels like and to be honest I barely remember how I experienced it.

But even though death on a technical level is the same—Life ends. Death is so incredibly different. It can come slowly after a period of illness or quickly and violently. It can come after a long and rich life or far too early.

The question of where the final farewell will be is connected to the question of where people die. Where do I want to die? The question came to me quite late in the project. I have thought about where I would like to be buried and some thought has certainly been devoted to a hypothetical funeral. But I had not thought about which room I would like to die in before. Instinctively I feel that I do not want to die in my apartment in

Björkhagen. Then I would rather die in my old apartment in Gothenburg. The reason why I would rather die there is probably largely the hand-blown window panes from the early twenties that reflects the light to the most fantastic way. I would much rather die in that light than in the light we have in the apartment in Stockholm. It gives the room a soul. But ideally I would like to died looking out at the sea. To float out into the sea in death and become a part of it. I automatically thought at first that it would happen inside, but dying outside on a warm summer evening, half-lying by the sea dosen't sound to bad. But is that also how I want my loved ones to say goodbye to my body?

In the past, people died at home and therefore said their final goodbyes at home. But the idea of a home and what it meant to people must have been different to how it is today. A hometown and a sense of belonging to a place must be different if you live in the same place where your family has lived and died. Where does one feel at home these days? In a romantic idea of the sea. I can imagine dying in a hospital too. I don't feel aversion to hospitals like some people do. I even like hospitals. They are associated with security and help. It is a safe place. Several times I have gone to the hospital worried with a sick child that I didn't know what was wrong with, and as soon as a nurse looks at you and asks what's wrong, some of the worry goes away. It's no longer my responsibility. Now I will get help. There is something very peaceful about being in a constructed and to some extent authoritarian place where it is clear what you should feel and how you should behave.

It is not unusual that the first time you are in a room for farewells also is the first time you see a dead body—also the body of a person you love. This places high demands on how the room should communicate with the visitor. Katja Grillner describes in *From Postmodernism to Critical Regionalism* that if one sees critical regionalism as an architectural application of phenomenological dialectics:

> Architecture itself is seen as a mediator between subject and world, region and surrounding world. Architecture is also seen here as a kind of language but utilizes its entire spectrum of expressive possibilities to reach the subject. It does not require conscious translation into spoken language in order to be understood (Grillner 1994, p.71).

This is in contrast to postmodernism, which:

> What is meaningful for postmodernism to narrate is only what has meaning within the systems that govern humans, i.e. the linguistic ones. These may indeed be many and different, but cannot convey existential concepts of physical presence in the world without linguistic representation (Grillner 1994, p.71).

Working with traditional craft methods such as sweeping and carving has for me been a way of anchoring space in a historicall tradition. But in the same way that critical regionalism differs from sentimental regionalism, I have striven to mix the traditional with modern and contemporary expressions.

In early Jewish and Christian tradition, the temple and church were places where God existed, and if you wanted to meet God, you had to go to the church. Similarly, the sacred buildings built in ancient Egypt became the gods themselves. The Gods were given a permanent place on earth. Today, we live in a very digital world where communication between people can take place over long distances. Relationships are not as dependent on location as they used to be. But when a death occurs, that changes. Did you arrive on time? Is this one of the most common questions you hear when someone tells you about the passing of a loved one. When what previously "was" the person, their thoughts, movements and words, disappears, the body suddenly becomes the most important thing. And the body has a physical place. It cannot be conveyed via a digital screen. You need to *go* there. To the room for farewell, to be able to say a final goodbye.

Reflections and self-criticism

Method criticism

In the architect Helena Westerlind's PhD *Choreographing Flow- A Study in Concrete Deposition* she clarifies the distinction between the use of research in architectural practice and practice-based research. She writes that:

> In short, this can be described as the difference between research that is concerned with gaining knowledge which benefits the individual practitioner and investigative activities that are conducted with the purpose of being shared and scrutinized (Westerlind 2021, p.55).

A bit further down she continues with writing

> In order for creative design practice to constitute a valid research method, there must be an intention to learn and abstract some new and transmissible knowledge from the process of designing; the methods and outcomes of that process must further be open to scrutiny (Westerlind 2021, p.56).

Looking at my own work its clear that what I have been doing is to use research in my architectural practice. I had the intention to gain new knowledge in my process of creating but in order to validate the outcome as something more than just stuff that I made I need to test my design in a suitable context. The exhibition that I will write about further down could be seen as a starting point in trying out my design. But to really examine the outcome it has to be used and reviewed by both people working at the hospital and the morgue and people who have experience of using a room for farewell. What i have done that is maybe closer to gaining new knowledge is to combine method used in craft whit methods used in design. But more about that later, first some interesting findings i made that is possible openings for further research.

A power-critical examination of rooms for farewell and possible further research

I began this project with the ambition to make a room for farewell. I wanted to make furniture and objects that could help a person in moments of grief and emotional reflection. I wanted my objects to be a wordless help for the broken person. But during the course of the project, questions began to arise about what types of power this type of room could also be an example of and also how rooms for farewell may not live up to the latest research in bereaved's research. In the following paragraphs, I will provide brief insight into some different parts of and possibly problemat-

ic aspects of rooms for farewell. They are far from elaborate theories but should be seen as sketches of possible further research.

Which rooms are allowed to be beautiful?

Something that has incurred during my project is the clear distincion between which rooms that are allowed to be beautiful and which are not. This type of serious, sacred room, such as a room for farewells, cremations or funeral chapels, is often designed by an architect or an artist, and they are allowed to be beautiful and dont have as high demands on functionality as example a hostpital room. But why should it be saved for the dead? Of course, it is an important place and must be taken care of. I think everyone agrees on that. But why should the *cared for* and *poetic* only take place in these very special rooms. When you think of a room for farewells in a hospital, it is not far to start thinking about all the sick people who are in the surrounding rooms. How are these rooms designed? Hospitals are one of those places that are often described as sterile and distant from people. A place where functionality and economy are completely the deciding factor. But why shouldn't the dying person be allowed to stay in a beautiful and cared for room. Is there an absolute contradiction between a room that promotes life support and a room that provides quality of life. A research project is underway at Skellefteå Hospital where they are investigating whether hospital rooms decorated with wood panels can speed up patients' recovery and thereby reduce the time they need to spend in the hospital. Indications from a previous study in Tromsø show that factors such as views, wooden furnishings and the presence of green plants seem to be able to positively affect our health (Westerlund 2020).

Whose Body? - Biopolitics and Bereaved's Research

In my project, the *Woodland Cemetery* located south of Stockholm has often come up as a reference. Both from myself and from others. The cemetery was created by architects Gunnar Asplund and Sigurd Lewerentz and the entire complex is considered one of the most important works of modern architecture and was included in the UNESCO World Heritage List in 1994. Among many people I have spoken to, the forest cemetery is considered a good example of successful sacred architecture. A serious and beautiful place that works well as a place for funerals and a cemetery. But for others, especially younger people, the place is experienced as cold and frightening. There is something desolate and dark about the area. A style that, if nothing else, we have been taught to associate with good architecture. It is also an architecture and an urban planning and a way of building cemeteries that goes back to the beginning of the nineteenth century when the Parisian Père Lachaise cemetery was built. When it was built in 1804, it was the first garden cemetery and the first municipal cemetery in Paris. It is interesting because there are two clear changes in what a cemetery is and by extension the relationship to a dead person. First, the cemetery moves out of the central city. It stops being a part of everyday life and instead becomes a place where you have to go to visit. The second big change is that it is not a church that owns the cemetery, its the municipal. The responsibility for the dead and perhaps life after death is moved from the church to the state.

I would like to stay with these two changes that can be seen as a consequence of the modernization of society in the centuries after the Enlightenment, and see how they relate to my project.

If we start with the new location of cemeteries, from centrally located places to large garden cemeteries in the outside of towns. The Belgian architect and reacher Eva Demuynck states in her paper *The vocabulary of architectural consolation* that:

> The typology of the extra-muros cemetery initially offered a solution to the growing concerns regarding the health and hygiene of burial sites previously located at the heart of the city, but this relocation has also fostered a growing disconnection between the worlds of the dead and the living (Demuynck).

Demuynuck shows how this distance stands in contrast to "the bereaved's search for (re)connection with their deceased loved ones, as observed by western death and bereavement studies" (Demuynck). She continues with explaining how:

> Since the end of the 20th century, these studies have started to move away from theories promoting closure and detachment as the successful way to resolve grief, such as Freud's Mourning and Melancholia. Instead, they shifted their focus towards a process of continuing bonds between the bereaved and the deceased. This continued relationship between the living and the dead relies heavily on material foci or personal places of meaning, capable of evoking the sensation of the deceased's presence which can be both comforting and unsettling for the bereaved (Demuynck).

Rooms for farewell can be seen as a way to respond to the new research in bereavement studies by allowing the relatives to spend time with the dead body and thus begin to process what has happened. However, it is also possible to criticize the current arrangement, where visitors are given a limited time to visit the body and the farewell takes place in a special room far from home. Professor and midwife Ingela Rådestad has chosen to go a different way and has developed a special baby carrier with cooling blocks under the name Cubitus Baby where the dead baby can

be placed either during a continued stay in the hospital or if the parents want to take the body home for a shorter period (Krey 2013). What you otherwise need to do is place the body in a cold room or refrigerator, which creates discomfort and a feeling of unworthiness for many parents.

If you were to approach the issue of a room for farewell in a similar way, you could either imagine developing a similar cooling container but for a larger body. And that it could either be available at the hospital for a longer period of time, which could give the relatives more freedom as to how and when they want to come and visit the body, or if you should even be able to take the body home and say goodbye for a longer period of time in your home. As an interior architect, perhaps the assignment would be to design a type of semi-public cold room where visitors can come and go and more independently be able to pick up the body. A way where there is greater personal freedom and the possibility of variation.

If we instead look at the transition from church to state, we can look at Foucault's use of the term "Biopolitics". Natalie Akkadová givs a good short introduction to the term in her work *An Interpretative Phenomenological Analysis of Women's Childfree Decisions and the Influence of Biopolitics*

> In his pivotal work The History of Sexuality, Volume 1, Foucault describes a major shift in how power is exercised in modern societies. He contrasts sovereign power, the classical model in which rulers held the authority to "take life or let live", with modern biopower, which is defined by its aim to "make live and let die." This new form of power centres on the management of life itself: on optimising, fostering, regulating, and producing health, reproduction, and the well-being of populations (Akkadová 2025, p.16).

In the early 2010s, the peripheral pop drummer Kristian Gidlund suddenly became a household name in Sweden. After being diagnosed with stomach cancer in 2011, he began writing a blog with the name *I kroppen min (in* my *body)* where he, in an everyday and poetic way, shared the experience of the disease and the future he would not experience (Gidlund 2011-2013). The blog became an enormous success and was published in book format. I came to think of the book when I read about biopolitics and its connection to room for farewell and the ownership of a body. In Gidlund's title, he presumes something that for the vast majority of people in Sweden is considered self-evident. The body, the body that is me, is mine. Whether this is true or not I will not go into detail here, but if you instead ask yourself when a person dies, who owns the body?

> Regardless of where the death occurs, it is the County Council/ Municipality that is responsible for transporting the deceased to a morgue. (…) According to the law, burial or cremation must take place within one month of the date of death"(Björkdahls begravningsbyrå).

The ashes after cremation can either be placed in an urn grave, a columbarium or a memorial garden. If you want to scatter the ashes, you need to apply for permission from the County Administrative Board and it is never allowed to keep the ashes at home (Länsstyrelsen). So from that point of view, the dead body is not only a matter for the person or their loved ones, but something that is regulated by clear laws.

If there has now been a shift from the dead body belonging to God and then the church, to now belonging to the state, what does that have to do with the Room for Farewell. Why does this room exist then? Is it a way to control life and death and decide when and how the grief and farewell can and should take place?

Conclusion

When I read the excerpts from Helena Westerlind's PhD *Choreographing Flow- A Study in Concrete Deposition* where she writes about the distinction between the use of research in architectural practice and practice-based research, I was, as I wrote earlier, a little discouraged. Has my project really done anything at all? Have I just made stuff and used myself as a judge? But after discussing the project with others and gaining even more distance from it, I begin to see the parts that in some way lie beyond the linguistic, the intuitive material process that is the basic state of the craftsman, what New Materialist are partly trying to capture but which I think has always been present for those who work a lot with craft. Then you already know that a material is not a mute entity that can be shaped exactly as you want. You know that when you put wood as a surface in a rendering, it has very little to do with what *wood* is. It goes without saying that the material itself has a will and that craft is not about taming that will but listening to it.

David Pye writes that "In practice the designer hopes the workmanship will be good, but the workman decides whether it shall be good or not" (Pye 1968, p.17) In my presentation of my work earlier in the text, I have perhaps taken more the role of designer. I try to explain my design choices and account for my process as if it has followed a logical sequence of events. Continuing that logic, you end up in the conclusion I made above that to see if the project has been successful, you need to control the outcome with the help of some type of control group. But in the project, I have been as much a *workman* as a *designer*. In the encounter with each piece of wood, I have made decisions based on that piece of wood to produce the best possible result. And if there is anything good about my

work, it is that method, to move seamlessly between the designer and the craftsman. In my first draft of the project description for this work, I wrote that "I have always placed my hope that my strength as a designer is my knowledge in craft, and that my strength as a crafts person is my knowledge in design. But during my time here at Konstfack I have started to doubt it." In retrospect, I see that in this project I have found my way back to that symbiosis. But in this project, there is also a third component that has to do with theory and absorbing information and knowledge from books and conversations and then putting it into practice.

I write that I have three different ways of working—the designer, the craftsman, and the researcher, but it is probably more truthful that all three parts are happening at the same time and that I move around them in a constantly ongoing loop that grows and grows with each turn. Which is also the way that my objects took shape. There was not a research part that then led into a design part and then ended in a manufacturing part. All parts have been present the whole time. And as I have moved around in this loop, the objects have taking shape one by one and then been drawn into the loop as another entity to relate to. In this way, the space and my understanding of the it have grown in parallel.

Working in this way requires presence. Perhaps that is why I am so drawn to Pallasmaa's and Holl's ideas, because they focus so much on presence. Holl writes in *Questions of Perception* that we must become "activists in presence" (Holl 2016, p. 41). Above all, craft requires presence. I think that is partly what Pye means when he writes about *workmanship of risk*. The presence that opens up the possibility that anything can happen in the course of the work. Risk both requires and creates presence. But in Pallasmaa and Holl's case, and also mine, the ambition is to create presence in the user of the designed environments. A common trap to fall into as a creator is to believe that an exciting process is to be equated with an exciting result. Just because I have been forced to be present in the creation of the space does not mean that the same experience is transferred to the user. Although this does not apply to all creative processes, I believe that it is often the case when it comes to craft. The special thing about craft, if we are talking about more traditional crafts, is that it bears traces of the time it has taken to make it. Nordström touches on this when she writes about weaving funeral palls. A man who has lost his wife has used one of her blankets at the funeral and when they meet the week after the funeral he returns to the fact that it took so long to weave the blanket.

> The fact that I had been weaving for a month became something he returned to, time and time again, and I have thought about it a lot afterwards. Did the idea of the relative slowness of the craft become a kind of anchor to help him navigate his chaos more easily?

Picture on right side: Installation view from the spring exhibition at konstfack 2026 (Own photograph, 2026)

(Nordström 2016, p.67).

I think there is a lot of truth in Nordström's reflection on this, that the slowness and the long time it took to make something can ground the viewer and, in some way, create a presence in the present.

In my project I have often returned to the sequence in Nordström's book about when she is asked about weaving infant wrapping cloths. But this passage about how the slowness of the craft can be a kind of anchor to help a person navigate his chaos is actually just as central. In some way, her she gives the key to answering the question she gets from the Australian obstetrician. How this thing that is supposed to be handed over when words are not enough should be designed. It should be created through craft.

In the introduction to *The Poetics of Space*, Bachelard writes that the poetic image meets the reader not as a symbol for something else but as a force in itself. "In poems, forces appear that do not cross the circles of knowledge" (Bachelard 2024, p.28). It is not what the words describe and how the reader interprets these words on an intellectual level that is the power of a poetic image, but how it reaches and creates a resonance deep within us (Bachelard 2024, p.29). He further writes that "the resonance urges us to a deepening of our own existence" (Bachelard 2024, p.29). There we have the presence, but also the ambition of my work. The objects may be created based on different reasoning and thoughts and carry symbols and metaphors, but for the viewer these should not stand in the way of the encounter and hopefully some type of resonance. The door is perhaps the best example of this. For me it is packed with symbolism and I believe it creates qualities in it that have nothing to do with being able to read the symbols but rather that they together create a poetic image.

My material

I write at the beginning of the text that I want to be inspired by the neo-materialist way of thinking and relating to material and to try to listen more to the material and the tools, to see the forms and properties that are already in them. A quote by Jorge Luis Borges is often brought up by phenomenologists to describe how meaning is created;

> The taste of the apple…lies in the contact of the fruit with the palate, not in the fruit itself; in a similar way…poetry lies in the meeting of the poem and reader, not in the lines of symbols print-

1 As quoted by Juhani Pallasmaa in *The Eyes of the Skin: Architectureand the Senses*

Picture on right side: Installation view from the spring exhibition at konstfack 2026 (Photograph by Gustav Karlsson Frost, 2026)



> ed on the pages of a book. What is essential is the aesthetic act, the thrill, the almost physical emotion that comes with each reading..[1]

When I first read it, it felt true. The world comes to life in the encounter with it. But as soon as you think a little more about it, it quickly becomes bland. It makes one think of the thesis that *man is the measure of all things*, a saying attributed to the Greek philosopher and sophist Protagoras. A thesis that today can feel quite outdated. If you look at the political and business world, it is rather money and power that are the measure of all things, but if you instead follow the modern theory within transhumanism and new materialism, all things are given a place and are given their own agency. In *Reciprocal Landscapes*, Jane Hutton follows the material journey of five different building elements and plants, from the place in the world where they have grown or been mined to their current location in Manhattan, New York. I came to think of the text when I myself had the opportunity to work with wooden materials that have grown, felled, sawn, and dried just a few miles from the place where I have then built objects with them. Each tree is marked so that it is possible to find out exactly which plank comes from which tree and where it has grown. But as Hutton also writes, "the notion of an origin […] is suspicious from the start:: where does a material begin anyways?" (Hutton 2019, p.7) But even if matter of course is something constantly changing, starting perhaps in the big bang and ending in a future implosion, I believe (as I also understand Hutton's book) that by paying attention to at least part of the material's history, we become more empathetic to it and begin to become more responsive to its own agency. It stops being just *material* and instead becomes *this material*. The small scale of the sawmill that saws up the trees already creates an opportunity to meet each tree as it is, and when I then continue to work with it, the interaction continues, but now between me and the material. My vision meets the will of the material and we shape each other. Ron Richardson describes it as "When we seek to learn how to work with an object which we require to attain some end we are seeking to be changed by interaction with it" (Richardson 2020).

When the room was ready the day before the exhibition open, it was clear to me how what I had read, the people I had talked to, the material I had worked with, and my thoughts had shaped the project into what it became, but also, that all of that together had shaped me.

Closing words

May 14, 2026 - the exhibition

The day after the opening, my head is finally above water again. In recent weeks I have let go of control and just worked. The project has somehow been completed in me and I have been able to let my hands work freely. Two completely new objects have been added and the others have been completed. It has no longer been an intellectual struggle to move forward, even though I have had to test my way through the design. But now the exhibition is up and the room that has gradually grown with the help of the various objects is now assembled and has met its first visitors. It is of course a specific audience and it is not difficult to imagine that it is those who appreciate the work who have a greater tendency to say something about it. But having said that, I have received a lot of words about how people appreciate the peace and quiet, that it is very beautiful and several of the visitors say that they wish they had had access to this room when they had experience loss earlier in their lives. I personally feel as if I have just come above the water surface again and have difficulty judging whether what I have done is just a lot or whether it is also good.

Closing reflection - The most beautiful thing you can do

Even if it is possible to see *rooms for farewells* and that a type of controlled farewell in constructed places, the fact still remains that farewells take place in these rooms on a daily basis. And then and there it doesn't matter, it is only *that* moment and *that* farewell that are important and it is mainly for *them* that I have done this project. When Nordström looks back at the first batch of infant wrapping cloths she wove, she is struck by how she had tried to make something as beautiful as possible. (Nordström 2016, p.120) The painter Gunnar Larsson once had an exhibition titled *The most beautiful thing I can do!* That is a title I could have had for my project too. Not that it it's the most beautiful, but despite everything that has influenced my design, the ambition has basically been to make the most beautiful thing I can and hope that it can help someone in a difficult time.

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